

Task 2: Analyze a Phishing Email Sample

1.Objective:

To examine a suspicious email sample and identify phishing characteristics such as spoofed sender addresses, mismatched URLs, suspicious attachments, urgent language, and grammar errors. The goal is to document these red flags for cybersecurity awareness and defense.

2. What is phishing email

A phishing email is a type of cyberattack where attackers disguise themselves as trustworthy entities (like banks, government agencies, or popular companies) to trick recipients into revealing sensitive information such as passwords, credit card numbers, or personal details.

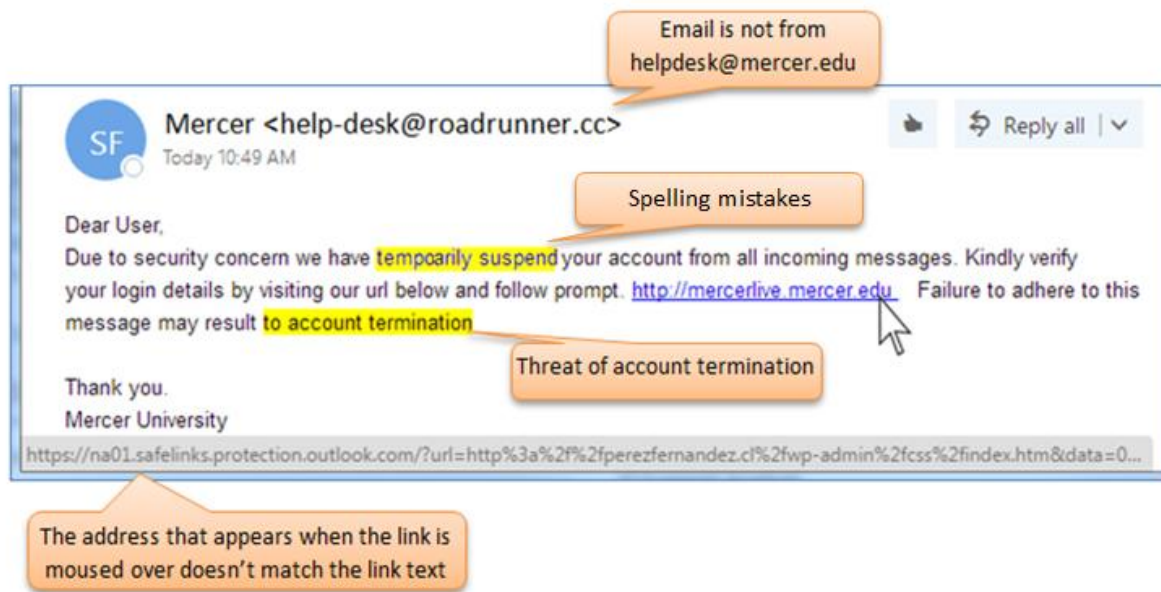
➤ Key Characteristics of Phishing Emails

- **Suspicious Sender Address:** Often looks similar to a legitimate one but with small changes (e.g., support@paypa1.com instead of support@paypal.com).
- **Urgency or Fear Tactics:** Messages pressuring you to act quickly, like “Your account will be suspended unless you verify now.”
- **Generic Greetings:** Instead of addressing you by name, they use “Dear Customer” or “Dear User.”
- **Links to Fake Websites:** Embedded links that lead to fraudulent sites designed to steal credentials.
- **Unexpected Attachments:** Files that may contain malware or ransomware.
- **Spelling/Grammar Errors:** Many phishing emails have noticeable mistakes.

➤ How to Protect Yourself

- Hover over links before clicking to check the real URL.
- Verify the sender’s email address carefully.
- Never share sensitive information via email.
- Use multi-factor authentication (MFA) for accounts.
- Report suspicious emails to your IT/security team or email provider.

3. Email Sample (Screenshot Simulation)



4. Summary Table of Phishing Traits

Trait	Evidence Example	Risk Level
Spoofed Sender Address	helpdesk@mercer.edu	High
Header Discrepancy	Return Path mismatch	High
Suspicious Link	https://na01.safelink.	High
Malicious Attachment	Any file	High
Urgent Language	To account termination	High
Generic Greeting	Dear user	Medium
Grammar Errors	Temporarily suspend	Medium

5. Conclusion

The suspicious email demonstrates multiple phishing characteristics, including spoofed sender details, mismatched URLs, urgent tone, and malicious attachments. These findings confirm the email is fraudulent and should be reported to the IT/security team.